TEXAS HOLD'EM FROM ZERO TO YOUR FIRST GAME

A Complete Illustrated Beginner's Guide to Learning, Playing, and Teaching Poker.



Designed for your 200-chip home poker set.

Special Section: Your First Game Step-by-Step Walkthrough

Part VI: Practice & Reference Chapters 17–20

PART I: UNDERSTANDING POKER

Chapter 1: Introduction to Poker

What is Texas Hold'em? Texas Hold'em is the world's most popular version of poker. The objective is to win the "pot" (the chips wagered during a hand) by either having the best five-card hand at the end, or by betting so confidently that all other players give up (fold) their cards.

Poker is a game of incomplete information. You know your cards, but you don't know your opponents' cards. You must balance the mathematics of chance (luck) with psychological strategy (skill) to win chips.

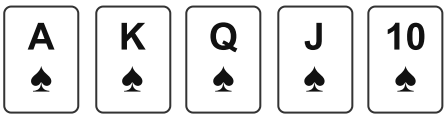
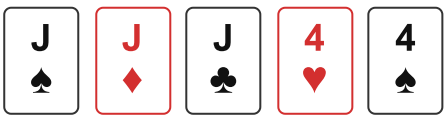
Chapter 2: Understanding Playing Cards

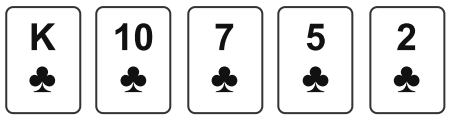
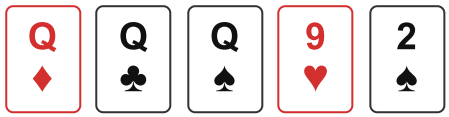
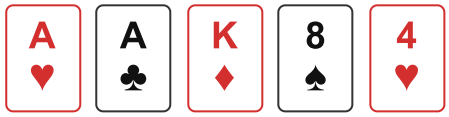
A standard deck has 52 cards divided into four **suits** (Spades, Hearts, Diamonds, Clubs). No suit is higher than another in Texas Hold'em.

Each suit has 13 **ranks**. From lowest to highest: 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, Jack (J), Queen (Q), King (K), Ace (A).
Note: The Ace can also be used as a "1" to make the lowest possible straight (A-2-3-4-5).

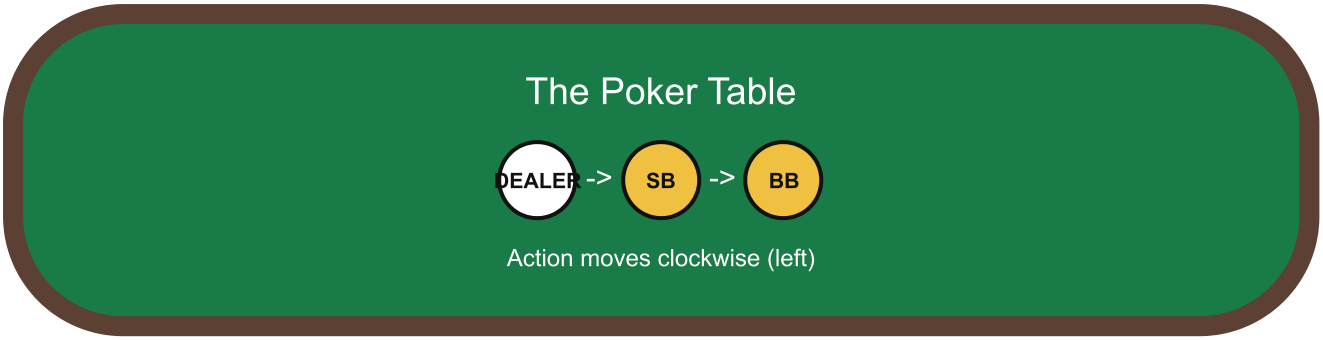
Chapter 3: Poker Hand Rankings

In Texas Hold'em, you must construct the best possible **five-card hand**. Here are the ten possible hands, ranked from highest to lowest. Print this page or keep it open when playing!

Rank	Hand Name & Description	Example
1	**Royal Flush** A, K, Q, J, 10 of the same suit. Unbeatable.	
2	**Straight Flush** Five cards in sequential order, all same suit.	
3	**Four of a Kind (Quads)** Four cards of the same rank.	
4	**Full House** Three of a kind PLUS a pair.	

Rank	Hand Name & Description	Example
5	**Flush** Five cards of the same suit, not in sequence.	
6	**Straight** Five cards in sequential order, mixed suits.	
7	**Three of a Kind (Trips/Set)** Three cards of the same rank.	
8	**Two Pair** Two distinct pairs of cards.	
9	**One Pair** Two cards of the same rank.	
10	**High Card** No matching cards. Highest card wins.	

The Kicker: If two players have the exact same pair (e.g., both have a pair of 10s), the winner is decided by the next highest card in their five-card hand, known as the "kicker." If the highest cards are tied, you look at the next card, and so on.



- **Dealer Button (The Button):** The best position. You get to act last during the hand.
- **Small Blind (SB):** Sits immediately to the left of the Dealer. Must put in a small forced bet before cards are dealt.
- **Big Blind (BB):** Sits immediately to the left of the SB. Must put in a large forced bet (usually double the SB) before cards are dealt.
- **Under the Gun (UTG):** Sits left of the Big Blind. They must act first before any community cards are dealt.

Chapter 5: Setting Up a Poker Game

Follow these steps to start your home game:

1. **Lay the mat:** Roll out your green poker mat.
2. **Banker:** One trusted player manages the Chip Rack. Distribute equal starting chips (e.g., 1,000 value).
3. **Determine the first Dealer:** Deal one card face up to each player. Highest card gets the Dealer Button.
4. **Set the Blinds:** Decide the blind values. For a 1,000 stack, a good start is 10 for the Small Blind and 20 for the Big Blind. Give the SB and BB buttons to the players left of the dealer.
5. **Shuffle and Deal:** The dealer shuffles the deck and deals exactly two cards face down to each player, starting with the Small Blind.

Chapter 6: Poker Actions

When it is your turn, you must choose one of the following actions:

- **Fold:** Throw your cards away. You lose any chips you put in the pot, but you risk no more.
- **Check:** Pass the action to the next player without betting. You can only check if no one has bet before you in this round.
- **Bet:** Place the first wager of the round into the pot.
- **Call:** Match the amount of the current highest bet. If the bet to you is 20, you put in 20.
- **Raise:** Increase the current bet. If the bet is 20, you must put in at least 40 (the call amount + a minimum raise equal to the previous bet).

- **All-In:** Bet all of your remaining chips. You cannot be forced to fold just because someone has more chips than you. If they bet 1000 and you only have 500, you can call "All-In" for 500 and create a side pot.

YOUR FIRST GAME: YOU AND YOUR FRIEND PLAY TEXAS HOLD'EM

This section is designed to be read *at the poker table* with a friend. Set up your mat and chips right now. We are going to walk through a completely realistic, mathematically perfect two-player (Heads-Up) game, step by step.

Stage 1: Prepare the Game

You are **Player A**. Your friend is **Player B**. Sit across from each other.

Take your 200 chips. Assign values: White=1, Red=5, Green=25, Black=100. Give each player exactly 1,000 chips:

- 20 White (20)
- 10 Red (50)
- 5 Green (125)
- 8 Black (800) *Wait, let's use the exact math from Chapter 5: 20 White (20), 10 Red (50), 5 Green (125), 8 Black (800) = 995. Let's adjust to 1000: 20 White (20) + 16 Red (80) + 4 Green (100) + 8 Black (800) = 1000. Give yourselves this exact stack.*

Stage 2: Heads-Up Positions

Two-player poker ("Heads-Up") has special rules for the buttons:

- Give **Player A** the Dealer Button **AND** the Small Blind Button.
- Give **Player B** the Big Blind Button.

Rule to remember: Heads-up, the Dealer is always the Small Blind. The Dealer acts FIRST before the flop, and LAST after the flop.

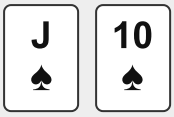
Stage 3: Post Blinds and Deal

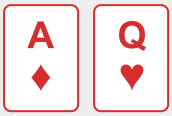
The Blinds for this hand are 10 / 20.

- **Player A (SB)** puts 10 (two red chips) in the middle. (Stack: 990)
- **Player B (BB)** puts 20 (four red chips) in the middle. (Stack: 980)

Pot Size: 30. Player A shuffles the deck and deals two cards face down to Player B, then two to Player A.

Look at your cards:

Player A has:  (Jack and Ten of Spades)

Player B has:  (Ace of Diamonds, Queen of Hearts)

Stage 4: Play Through Every Betting Round

1. Pre-Flop

Player A (Dealer/SB) acts first. The bet to match is the Big Blind (20). Player A already put in 10. Player A decides to **Call** by adding 10 more to the pot. (Player A Stack: 980).

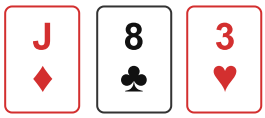
Player B is in the Big Blind. They can Check (since they already have 20 in) or Raise. Player B has a strong hand (A-Q) and decides to **Raise to 40**. Player B adds 20 more. (Player B Stack: 960).

Player A must Call the extra 20 to stay in. Player A puts 20 more in. (Player A Stack: 960).

Current Pot: 80. Betting is equal. Move to Flop.

2. The Flop

Player A deals three community cards face up:



(Player A now has a pair of Jacks. Player B has Ace high).

After the flop, Player B acts first. Player B decides to **Bet 40** to bluff. (Player B Stack: 920).

Player A has top pair and decides to **Call** by matching the 40. (Player A Stack: 920).

Current Pot: 160 (80 + 40 + 40). Move to Turn.

3. The Turn

Player A deals the fourth community card:



(Player B just hit a Pair of Queens! Player A still has a Pair of Jacks, but is close to a Straight: 8-? -10-J-Q).

Player B acts first. Feeling confident with the Queens, Player B **Bets 60**. (Player B Stack: 860).

Player A thinks they can still win if a 9 comes, so they **Call** 60. (Player A Stack: 860).

Current Pot: 280 (160 + 60 + 60). Move to River.

4. The River

Player A deals the fifth and final community card:



(Player A just hit a Straight! 8-9-10-J-Q. Player B still has a Pair of Queens).

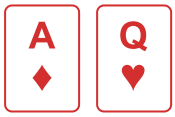
Player B acts first. Unsure of the 9, Player B **Checks** (bets 0).

Player A knows they have a very strong hand and **Bets 100**. (Player A Stack: 760).

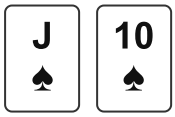
Player B decides their Queens are too good to fold, so they **Call** 100. (Player B Stack: 760).

Current Pot: 480. All betting is finished. Move to Showdown.

Stage 5: Reveal the Winner (Showdown)

Player B reveals: 

(Best 5 cards: Q-Q-A-J-9 for a Pair of Queens).

Player A reveals: 

(Best 5 cards: Q-J-10-9-8 for a Straight).

Looking at the Hand Ranking chart, a Straight beats a Pair. **Player A wins the pot!**

Push all 480 chips from the pot to Player A.

- **Player A's new stack:** 760 + 480 = **1,240 chips**.
- **Player B's new stack:** 760 = **760 chips**.

(Math check: 1,240 + 760 = 2,000 chips. Everything is perfect).

Stage 6: Start the Next Hand

To begin the next hand:

1. Collect all 52 cards.
2. Pass the Dealer Button and Small Blind Button to **Player B**.
3. Pass the Big Blind Button to **Player A**.
4. Player B posts 10 chips. Player A posts 20 chips. Player B deals. The game continues!

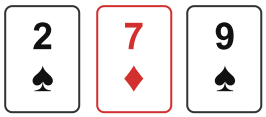
Chapter 13: Common Beginner Mistakes

- **Limping:** Just calling the Big Blind pre-flop instead of raising. If your hand is good enough to play, it's usually good enough to raise.
- **Chasing:** Calling big bets when you only have a draw (hoping for one specific card on the river) without considering the math.
- **Playing out of turn:** Always wait until the player to your right has acted.

PART VI: PRACTICE AND REFERENCE

Chapter 17: Guided Practice Hands

Scenario: You hold 

. The flop is 

. Your opponent bets 50 into a pot of 100.

Decision: You have an Ace-high flush draw (four spades, only need one more). You should **Call**. You have a very high chance of hitting your flush on the turn or river.

Chapter 18: Poker Mathematics for Beginners

The Rule of 2 and 4: If you are waiting on a specific card to complete your hand (like a flush), count how many cards in the deck help you (your "outs"). You have 4 spades. There are 13 spades total. 13 - 4 = 9 outs left in the deck.

- On the flop (two cards to come): Multiply outs by 4 (9 x 4 = 36% chance to hit).
- On the turn (one card to come): Multiply outs by 2 (9 x 2 = 18% chance to hit).

This simple math helps you know if a bet is worth calling!

Chapter 19: Poker Glossary

- **Board:** The five community cards.
- **Burn Card:** The top card of the deck discarded face down before dealing the flop, turn, or river (to prevent cheating).
- **Draw:** A hand that needs one more card to become a straight or flush.
- **Muck:** The pile of discarded cards; or the act of throwing your cards away.
- **Nuts:** The best possible unbeatable hand on a given board.

Betting Round	What Happens	Who Acts First
1. Pre-Flop	2 Hole Cards dealt to each player.	Player left of the Big Blind. (In Heads-Up, Dealer acts first).
2. The Flop	3 Community Cards dealt face up.	First active player left of Dealer.
3. The Turn	1 Community Card dealt face up.	First active player left of Dealer.
4. The River	Final Community Card dealt face up.	First active player left of Dealer.
5. Showdown	Reveal cards. Best 5-card hand wins pot.	The last player to bet or raise must show first.

Available Actions

- **Fold:** Throw cards away.
- **Check:** Bet nothing (only if no one has bet).
- **Call:** Match the current bet exactly.
- **Raise:** Increase the bet (must be at least double the previous bet/raise).

Standard Hand Rankings (Best to Worst)

1. **Royal Flush**
2. **Straight Flush**
3. **Four of a Kind**
4. **Full House**
5. **Flush**
6. **Straight**
7. **Three of a Kind**
8. **Two Pair**
9. **One Pair**
10. **High Card**

Home Game Checklist (200 Chips)

Assign Values: White(1), Red(5), Green(25), Black(100).
Start Stacks: 1,000 chips each.
Starting Blinds: 10 / 20.
Blind increases: Double every 20 minutes to force a winner.